Above and Beyond

The missing payment. Why it is the strongest story you have given me, the thing in it you mentioned in passing that is actually the whole answer, and the honest admission that makes it better rather than worse.

Doc 52 · "A time you went above and beyond" / "what does good client service look like" · Prepared 5 November 2026

1 Why this is your strongest story

Let me be direct, because you seem unsure about it.

This is **better than the house hunt, better than the society event, and arguably better than Pictet** for this particular question — because the stakes are real, the work was genuinely unasked-for, and it is a client service story that happens to involve a relative.

What the question wants	What you have
Genuine stakes	Someone's life savings, unaccounted for, in a foreign jurisdiction. Almost no student story comes close.
Nobody asked you	Not your money, not your purchase, no standing with any of the institutions involved. That is what makes it "beyond".
Specific actions, not sentiment	Phoned the recipient. Chased the intermediary. Read the contract when people stopped responding. Three distinct, describable moves.
A real outcome	You found it. Wrong emirate, held pending review, safe.
A reflection with something in it	Section 3 — and it is unusually good.

DO NOT APOLOGISE FOR IT BEING FAMILY

You may be tempted to open with "it's not a work example, but…". **Don't.** Apologising for your own story tells the reviewer to discount it, and they will.

Just tell it. The reflection does the connecting work, and the stakes more than justify it.

2 The thing you mentioned in passing that is the whole answer

You said, almost as an aside: *"whilst I was doing this, I was regularly keeping my relative updated with what was happening."*

That is the best thing in the story and you buried it. Here is why it matters.

THE MONEY WAS NEVER ACTUALLY LOST

It was sitting in a bank in Abu Dhabi, pending a government review, entirely safe. **It was always going to arrive.**

So what was the actual harm being done during those weeks? **Not the money. The not knowing.**

Which means that every time you came back with a partial update — *"I've spoken to the recipient, they haven't got it, I'm now chasing the people who issued the code"* — **you were solving the real problem before you had solved the apparent one.**

When somebody is frightened about money, **the absence of information is itself the damage.** You cannot always fix the problem. You can almost always fix the silence.

That is not a nice sentiment. It is the actual mechanism of client service in finance, and it transfers directly:

- A pension trustee whose portfolio is down 12% — **you cannot fix the market.** What you control is whether they are informed, and whether they can explain it to their own board.
- A client waiting on a mandate decision, an onboarding, a transfer — the delay is often outside your control. The silence is not.

WHY THIS IS THE REFLECTION TO USE

Most candidates answering "above and beyond" describe effort — *I worked late, I did extra.* Effort is not interesting; everyone claims it.

You can describe a judgement: that you worked out what the person actually needed, which was not the money arriving but knowing where it was. That is a different and much higher-order observation, and it is true.

3 The honest admission that makes it stronger

Here is the move that will separate this from every other answer, and it is counterintuitive.

> Admit that **you did not change the outcome.** The money would have arrived anyway. The review was going to take as long as it took. **What you changed was the experience of waiting.**

Most people would hide that, because it sounds like diminishing your own contribution. It does the opposite:

- It is **true**, and a reviewer who thinks about it will spot it anyway. Saying it first is far better than being caught not having noticed.
- It shows you can **locate value accurately** — you know which part of what you did actually mattered.
- And it makes the lesson land, because the lesson *is* that the information was the thing of value.

> THE SENTENCE
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> *"Looking back, I didn't actually change the outcome — the money was always going to arrive, and the review was going to take as long as it took. What I changed was the three weeks of not knowing. And I think that's usually the bit you can actually do something about."*

4 Two other things you are underselling

1 · YOU WENT TO THE DOCUMENT WHEN THE PEOPLE STOPPED RESPONDING

You said: the people who issued the code were not replying, *so you went into the contract* to understand what would happen if the money were genuinely lost.

That is exactly the right instinct and most people would not have it. When you cannot get information from humans, get it from the paper. And you were not just reading for comfort — you were establishing what the actual exposure was.

That is risk thinking, and it is a small but genuine mark of someone who would be useful in a financial firm.

2 · YOU CHECKED RATHER THAN ASSUMING IT WAS FINE

The default assumption was that international transfers are slow and it would turn up. That assumption was *mostly* right — the money was safe — **but it was also wrong in an important way, because it had gone to the wrong emirate entirely.**

So your instinct to investigate was vindicated: there genuinely was a problem, even though the outcome was fine. Say that. It justifies the whole effort retrospectively.

5 Privacy — and why being careful scores

DO NOT SAY THE AMOUNT, AND DO NOT IDENTIFY THE RELATIVE

You are describing a family member's private finances in a recording that strangers will watch.

Say "a relative" and "their life savings" or "a significant sum". Never the number, never the name, never the relationship if it is identifying.

This is not just etiquette. **A candidate who is visibly careful with other people's financial information is signalling something directly relevant to the job** — and the contrast with candidates who overshare is noticed.

THE NUMBERS YOU CAN USE, WHICH ARE ALL NON-IDENTIFYING

How long it had been missing when you started — days, weeks? This is your strongest number.
How long it took you to locate it — days? That is the result.
How many institutions you dealt with — the recipient, the intermediary, the bank. Three or four?
How many calls, roughly, if you remember.

"It had been unaccounted for about three weeks, and I traced it over four days" is a quantified result that gives away nothing private. **Go and work out the real figures tonight.**

6 The full answer

About 110 seconds. STAR-R, with the reflection doing the heavy lifting.

SITUATION — ~22 SECONDS

So this was outside work. A relative of mine was buying a property in Dubai from the UK, and he'd let me sit alongside the process, partly because I was interested. He'd liquidated what was essentially his life savings to fund it, and we'd sent the money across.

We were supposed to get confirmation it had landed within a few days. It never came. [And by the time I got involved it had been unaccounted for about X weeks.]

TASK — ~15 SECONDS

Nobody asked me to do anything about it. It wasn't my money and I had no standing with any of the institutions involved. But I could see what it was doing to him, and he was working full time — so realistically if I didn't chase it, nobody was going to.

ACTION — ~40 SECONDS

So I started at the receiving end and worked backwards. I phoned the people who were meant to have received it, explained the situation, and established they definitely hadn't. Then I went to the intermediaries who'd given us the payment details — and they stopped responding.

So at that point I went into the contract, because if I couldn't get information out of people I wanted to understand what the paper said — specifically what the position would be if the money genuinely had gone missing. Partly to know how worried to be.

And the thing I did throughout, which I think mattered more than any of the rest of it, was keep him updated even when I had nothing to tell him. So — I've spoken to the recipient, they haven't got it, I'm now chasing the people who issued the code. Not an answer, but not silence either.

RESULT — ~15 SECONDS

It turned out the money had gone to a bank in Abu Dhabi rather than Dubai, and was sitting there pending a government review — which is why nobody had confirmed anything. It was safe the whole time. [I found it in about X days.] And he said he'd never have had the time to chase it, so at least he knew where it was and what the next step had to be.

REFLECTION — ~22 SECONDS

And the honest reflection is that I didn't change the outcome. The money was always going to arrive and the review was going to take as long as it took. What I changed was the weeks of not knowing.

Which I think is the thing I actually took from it — when someone's worried about money, quite often the problem isn't the thing that's gone wrong, it's not knowing what's gone wrong. You can't always fix the first one. You can nearly always fix the second.

7 The other version: if asked what good client service looks like

This story also answers that question, but as **evidence for a principle** rather than as a narrative. Shorter — about 75 seconds.

THE PRINCIPLE VERSION

"I think the honest answer is that good client service is mostly about reducing someone's uncertainty, because quite often you can't fix their actual problem.

The thing that made me think that was outside work. A relative was buying a property abroad with essentially his life savings, the money went across, and the confirmation never arrived. I ended up tracing it — it had gone to the wrong emirate and was sitting with a bank pending a government review.

But the thing I'd point to is that I updated him constantly even when I had nothing, because what was actually hurting him wasn't the money, it was not knowing where it was. The money was safe the whole time.

And I think that maps onto this quite directly. If a client's portfolio is down, you can't fix the market. What you can control is whether they're informed and whether they can explain it to their own board — and I'd rather be the person who turns up with a partial answer than the one who waits until they've got a good one."

8 Weak versus strong, same facts

HOW MOST PEOPLE WOULD TELL IT

"A family member was buying a property in Dubai and the money went missing. It caused a lot of panic and stress for everyone."

"I went above and beyond by making loads of calls and chasing it up, even though it wasn't my responsibility. I spent hours on the phone."

"Eventually I found that it had gone to the wrong bank. He was really grateful and said he couldn't have done it without me."

Problems: it is a story about effort, the communication point is missing entirely, and the ending is about being thanked.

YOURS, PROPERLY

"Nobody asked me. It wasn't my money and I had no standing with any of the institutions."

"I worked backwards from the receiving end. When the intermediaries stopped responding I went into the contract, because if I couldn't get information out of people I wanted to know what the paper said."

"And I updated him even when I had nothing to tell him. Not an answer, but not silence either."

"I didn't change the outcome — the money was always going to arrive. **What I changed was the weeks of not knowing.**"

What changed	Why it scores
"Nobody asked me" stated plainly	Establishes the "beyond" without claiming it. Let the reviewer conclude it.
Three distinct actions	Recipient, intermediary, contract. Specific moves beat "loads of calls".
Going to the document	Risk thinking, and an instinct most people do not have.
The updates foregrounded	Moves it from a story about effort to a story about judgement.
Admitting you didn't change the outcome	The most unusual move available, and it makes the lesson land.
Ending on the principle, not the thanks	"He was grateful" is about you. The principle is transferable.

9 What to cut

Cut	Because
The amount of money, or anything identifying	See section 5. Discretion is itself a signal.
"It caused panic" / heavy emotional language	Understated is stronger. "You could see what it was doing to him" is enough.
"I spent hours on the phone"	Effort claims. Say what you did and who you spoke to instead.
"He couldn't have done it without me"	Someone else's praise, reported by you, is weak evidence and reads as self-congratulation.
Criticising the intermediaries for not responding	Same rule as always — nobody in your story should be the villain. "They stopped responding" is a fact; "they were useless" is a complaint.
"It's not a work example, but…"	Never apologise for your own story.

10 Follow-ups

They ask	You say
"What if the money had been lost?"	You prepared for this at the time, so use it. "That's partly why I read the contract — I wanted to know what the position was before we needed to know. [*And what it said.*]"
"Isn't that just helping family?"	Don't get defensive. "It is. I'd say the part I'd carry into a job is less the helping and more what I learned about what people actually need when something's gone wrong with their money."
"What would you do differently?"	Honest and specific. "Start earlier. We waited a while assuming international transfers are just slow, and that was reasonable — but a quick check at day five would have cost nothing."
"How does that relate to this role?"	Straight to the principle. "A trustee whose portfolio is down — you can't fix the market, but you can make sure they're not dealing with silence as well."
"Were you qualified to be doing that?"	Cheerfully no. "Not remotely. I had no standing with any of them and I'd be surprised if I got far on my own authority — I was mostly asking questions and relaying. But nobody else was going to."

> **THE THREE SENTENCES THAT CARRY IT**
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> **1.** "Nobody asked me. It wasn't my money and I had no standing with any of them."
> **2.** "I updated him even when I had nothing to tell him. Not an answer, but not silence either."
> **3.** "I didn't change the outcome. What I changed was the weeks of not knowing."
>
> That third sentence is the best line in any story you have given me. Do not lose it.

What is mine and what is yours. Every fact is yours — the purchase, the liquidated savings, the missing confirmation, the calls to the recipient and the intermediaries, reading the contract, the regular updates, and the money sitting in Abu Dhabi pending review. What I have added is the framing: that the real harm was the uncertainty rather than the money, that your updates therefore solved the actual problem before the apparent one, that admitting you did not change the outcome strengthens rather than weakens the answer, and that going to the document when people stopped responding is risk thinking worth naming. The bracketed figures are yours to establish, and the privacy guidance in section 5 is advice rather than a rule — but I would follow it.